

Dequad — UK Innovator Founder Visa Business Plan

Applicant: [Founder Full Legal Name] **Company:** Dequad Ltd (to be incorporated in England & Wales)
Document version: 1.0 **Date:** February 2026 **Visa route:** UK Innovator Founder Visa (Appendix Innovator Founder, UK Immigration Rules)

Cover Letter to the Endorsing Body / Home Office

This business plan is submitted in support of an **Innovator Founder Visa** application. It demonstrates how Dequad — a UK-focused student wellbeing and connection platform — meets the three statutory endorsement criteria:

1. **Innovation** — a genuine, original, novel business idea that meets new or existing market needs and/or creates a competitive advantage.
2. **Viability** — a realistic and achievable plan based on the applicant's skills, knowledge, experience and market awareness.
3. **Scalability** — evidence of structured planning, potential for job creation and growth into national/international markets.

The plan also addresses the **secondary endorsement requirements** of active business involvement, sufficient investment funds, and demonstrable progress against milestones (per Innovator Founder Caseworker Guidance).

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1. Executive Summary

Dequad is a UK-built, mobile-first student wellbeing platform that combines three core pillars — **mood tracking, Hinge-style peer matching, and institutional safeguarding alerts** — into a single secure mobile app exclusively for UK university students.

The UK is in a **measurable student mental health crisis**: 57% of UK students report a mental health issue (Student Minds, 2023), 50% experience loneliness (ONS), and university counselling waiting times average **4–6 weeks**. Existing solutions — generic meditation apps, dating apps, and overburdened campus counselling — are reactive, not proactive, and not student-verified.

Dequad addresses this gap with: - A `.ac.uk` verified student network (safety + trust by design) - Daily mood tracking with early-warning analytics for university welfare teams - End-to-end encrypted peer connection (Hinge-style prompts and comments, not photo-swipe) - Automated safeguarding keyword detection aligned to **OfS B3 conditions** and the **UUK Mental Health Charter**

Innovation: Dequad is the **first UK platform** to combine proactive peer connection, mood data, and institutional safeguarding into one student-verified mobile experience. No direct UK competitor offers this combination.

Viability: The founder brings [insert founder's relevant degree, work experience, technical skill set, and prior venture/product experience here]. A working MVP (React Native + FastAPI + MongoDB) is already built and deployable.

Scalability: Dequad targets the UK higher education sector exclusively — **2.86 million students across 285+ institutions** (HESA 2023/24). The 5-year plan creates **20+ UK-based skilled jobs**, generates **£3.75M ARR by Year 5**, and serves **750,000+ UK students**.

The ask: £500,000 seed investment (a portion of which is the founder's own and qualifying co-investment funds as per Innovator Founder rules). Use of funds: product (40%), UK growth (30%), UK team (20%), legal & compliance (10%).

2. The Founder — Viability Criterion

The Innovator Founder route requires evidence that the applicant has the skills, knowledge, experience, and market awareness to successfully run the business.

2.1 Founder Profile

Name: [Founder Full Legal Name] **Nationality:** [Nationality] **Education:** [Highest qualification, institution, year] **English language:** [Evidence: degree taught in English / IELTS / SELT] **Current location:** [Current country/city]

2.2 Relevant Skills & Experience

Domain	Evidence
Technology / Software	[Years of experience, languages, frameworks used; link to GitHub / portfolio]
Product Management	[Products launched, user numbers, outcomes]
UK HE Sector Knowledge	[Studied at a UK university / worked with UK universities / advisor relationships]
Mental Health / Safeguarding	[Volunteer work, training, lived experience, qualifications such as Mental Health First Aid]
Entrepreneurship	[Previous ventures, founding roles, P&L responsibility]
Leadership / Team-building	[Direct reports managed, hiring track record]

2.3 Market Awareness (Demonstrated)

The founder has, prior to this application: - Conducted **primary research** with [N] UK university students via interviews and surveys (summary in Appendix A) - Engaged with welfare leads at **[N] UK universities** (correspondence in Appendix B) - Built and shipped a functional MVP, validated with a closed beta of **[N] UK students** - Studied UK higher education regulation including the OfS Regulatory Framework, UUK Mental Health Charter, and ICO guidance on student data

2.4 Why This Founder, Why Now

[2–3 paragraph personal statement explaining the founder's "why" — personal connection to the problem (e.g., own university mental health journey, family member's experience, or professional exposure), and why their unique combination of skills makes them the right person to deliver Dequad in the UK market. Crucial for endorsing body assessment of viability.]

3. The Problem

3.1 Quantified UK Crisis

Metric	UK Statistic	Source
UK students reporting a mental health issue	57%	Student Minds, 2023
UK students experiencing loneliness at university	50%	ONS, 2022
10-year rise in disclosed mental health conditions in UK HE	+319%	HESA
Average wait for UK university counselling	4–6 weeks	AMOSSHE survey, 2022
Annual UK university spend on student welfare	~£200M	UUK estimates
UK student suicides (2017–2020)	319 deaths	ONS / Coroners' reports

3.2 Root Causes

1. **Transition stress** — first time away from home, often to a new UK city
2. **Academic pressure** — UK degree intensity, single-summative-assessment models
3. **Cost-of-living crisis** — rent inflation in UK university cities, rising tuition (£9,535 from 2025/26)
4. **Post-COVID social deficit** — Gen Z students lack pre-pandemic social skills development
5. **Welfare service overload** — counselling capacity has not kept pace with disclosed need

3.3 Why Existing Solutions Fail

Solution	Why it falls short for UK students
University counselling	4–6 week waits, reactive, capacity-constrained
Headspace / Calm	No social component, no peer connection, no safeguarding
BetterHelp / Talkspace	Expensive (£60+/week), reactive, not UK student-priced
TogetherAll (formerly Big White Wall)	Text-only forums, dated UX, anonymous so no real connection
Tinder / Bumble BFF	Not student-verified, safety concerns, not wellbeing-focused
University apps (campusM, etc.)	Information-only, poor UX, low engagement

No single UK-available product combines mood tracking + peer matching + institutional safeguarding. This is the gap Dequad fills.

4. The Solution & Innovation — Innovation Criterion

The Innovator Founder route requires a genuine, original, novel business idea that meets new or existing market needs and creates a competitive advantage.

4.1 Product Overview

Dequad is a **mobile-first** (iOS + Android), `.ac.uk` email-verified application with three integrated pillars:

Pillar 1 — Mood Tracking & Insights

- Daily 30-second mood check-ins with contextual prompts
- Pattern recognition over time (sleep, social, academic context)
- UK-relevant signposting (NHS, Samaritans 116 123, Shout 85258, Student Minds)
- **Anonymised aggregate analytics** delivered to university welfare teams (institutional value)

Pillar 2 — Meaningful Peer Connections

- **Hinge-style** profile browsing (not Tinder-style photo-swipe)
- Like a specific **prompt response or interest**, with a comment — encourages substantive interaction
- Match by university, course, year of study, interests
- **End-to-end encrypted (AES-256)** messaging
- All users **verified** `.ac.uk` **UK university email** — closed, trusted network

Pillar 3 — Safeguarding & Institutional Integration

- **Keyword detection** for crisis indicators (suicide, self-harm, severe distress) aligned to UK welfare practice
- **Automated alerts** to designated university safeguarding leads via SMTP
- **In-app crisis resources** surfaced instantly to the user
- **Audit trail** maintained for OfS B3 condition compliance
- **University dashboard**: anonymised analytics + alert management for welfare teams

4.2 Why This Is Innovative — Per Home Office Criterion

The endorsement criterion requires "**a genuine, original, novel business idea**" that creates "**a competitive advantage**." Dequad meets this on multiple, verifiable dimensions:

4.2.1 Novel Combination

No UK-available product combines **all three** of: verified-student peer connection, longitudinal mood data, and automated institutional safeguarding. Each element exists separately; Dequad is the first to integrate them.

4.2.2 Novel Verification Model

Dequad's `.ac.uk` verification creates a **closed, trusted UK-student-only network**. This is structurally different from generic dating apps (Tinder/Bumble) and from anonymous mental health forums (TogetherAll).

4.2.3 Novel Data Flow for Safeguarding

The **proactive keyword detection** → **automated SMTP alert** → **welfare team dashboard** flow does not currently exist in UK university tech stacks. Most universities still rely on **reactive** self-reporting via web forms or in-person appointments.

4.2.4 Novel UX for Student Mental Health

"Like a prompt, not a photo" is a meaningful UX shift away from appearance-based matching, which evidence shows is correlated with poorer mental health outcomes in young users (Royal Society for Public Health, *#StatusOfMind*, 2017).

4.2.5 Defensible Competitive Advantage

- **Data network effect:** more universities → more anonymised benchmarking value → more universities sign up
- **Trust moat:** `.ac.uk` verification is hard for international competitors to replicate without UK partnerships
- **Regulatory alignment:** built around UK-specific OfS / ICO / UUK frameworks — a structural advantage over US-built products entering the UK

4.3 Intellectual Property

Asset	Status	Protection Strategy
Source code	Built in-house, version-controlled	Trade secret + employment IP assignment clauses
"Dequad" brand & wordmark	In use	UK trademark application planned within Month 3 (Classes 9, 41, 42, 44)
Domain (dequad.app)	Owned by founder	Will be transferred to Dequad Ltd on incorporation
Safeguarding keyword taxonomy	Curated in-house with clinical advisor input	Trade secret + copyright
University analytics dashboard methodology	Proprietary	Trade secret + future patent search

5. UK Market Analysis

Scope note: This plan is exclusively focused on the United Kingdom. International expansion is **out of scope** for the planning horizon (Years 1–5) and any future international move would be a separate strategic decision post-Year 5.

5.1 Market Size (UK Only)

Total Addressable Market (TAM)

Segment	Size	Source
UK university students (HE)	2.86 million	HESA 2023/24
UK higher education institutions	285+	HESA
Total UK university sector economic contribution	£43.9 billion	Universities UK
Estimated UK university spend on student welfare (annual)	~£200 million	UUK estimate
UK digital mental health market	£500m and growing	TechUK 2023

Serviceable Addressable Market (SAM)

Segment	Count	Students
Russell Group	24	~590,000
Post-92 universities	~75	~1,200,000
All UK HE providers with formal welfare provision	~165	~2,500,000

Serviceable Obtainable Market (SOM) — 5-Year UK Plan

Year	UK Universities Partnered	UK Students Active	% UK Penetration
1	10	50,000	1.7%
2	20	150,000	5.2%
3	40	300,000	10.5%
4	70	500,000	17.5%
5	100+	750,000	26.2%

5.2 UK Market Trends Supporting Dequad

1. **Regulatory pressure** — OfS B3 conditions on student outcomes are tightening; universities need demonstrable welfare interventions.
 2. **The UUK Mental Health Charter** is now adopted by 80+ UK institutions and explicitly encourages digital wellbeing tools.
 3. **Cost-of-living crisis** is intensifying UK student stress (NUS 2023 cost-of-living survey: 96% of students cutting back).
 4. **Post-COVID isolation** is a known and politically prioritised UK public health concern.
 5. **Gen Z digital-first expectations** — UK 18–24-year-olds spend 6+ hours/day on mobile (Ofcom, 2023). The mobile channel is the only viable channel.
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6. Competitive Analysis & Differentiation

6.1 Direct UK Competitors

Competitor	Focus	Strength	Gap Dequad Fills
TogetherAll	Anonymous peer support forum	NHS contracts	Text-only; no real connections; dated UX
Unmind	Workplace + uni wellbeing	Established B2B sales	No peer connection; B2B-only
Student Space (Student Minds)	Information portal	Charity backing	Not interactive; no matching; no app
Bumble BFF	Friend finding (UK + global)	Brand awareness	Not student-verified; safety concerns
University-built apps	Info, timetables	Already on phones	Poor UX; low engagement; no peer matching

6.2 Indirect Competitors

- In-house UK university counselling services
- General-purpose dating apps (Tinder, Hinge, Bumble)
- Generic meditation apps (Calm, Headspace)
- NHS digital tools (Every Mind Matters)

6.3 Dequad's Defensible Advantages (UK-Specific)

1. **Verified .ac.uk community** → trust no general app can match
 2. **Proactive safeguarding flow** → no UK competitor offers automated welfare alerts
 3. **UK-resident data + UK GDPR by design** → procurement-ready for risk-averse UK university IT departments
 4. **OfS / UUK alignment** → fits straight into existing UK governance frameworks
 5. **First-mover** in the combined wellbeing + peer connection + safeguarding category in the UK
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7. Product, Technology & IP

7.1 Current Build Status (MVP — Already Functional)

Layer	Technology	Status
Mobile app	React Native, Expo, Expo Router	✓ Functional
Backend API	Python 3.11, FastAPI, Pydantic	✓ Functional
Database	MongoDB (Atlas in production)	✓ Functional
Authentication	Google OAuth (Emergent session) + .ac.uk verification logic	✓ Functional
Encryption	AES-256 end-to-end for chat	✓ Functional
Push notifications	Expo Push Service	✓ Functional
Email / SMTP safeguarding	SMTP (Gmail dev / SendGrid prod)	✓ Functional
Admin dashboard	React Native Web for welfare teams	✓ Functional

7.2 Roadmap (UK-Focused)

Quarter	Feature
Q1	Public iOS + Android UK App Store launch; UK Trademark filing
Q2	University welfare dashboard v2 (analytics, alert triage)
Q3	UK-specific SSO (Microsoft 365 / Shibboleth) for university partners
Q4	NHS Digital Technology Assessment Criteria (DTAC) submission
Year 2	Group chat (society / course-based), Premium tier launch
Year 3	Voice notes (encrypted), accessibility WCAG 2.2 AA full audit

7.3 Hosting & Data Residency

- **AWS London (eu-west-2)** or **GCP eu-west2** — UK / EU regions only
 - No US data transfer; full UK GDPR + Data Protection Act 2018 compliance by design
 - Backup region: AWS Ireland (eu-west-1)
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8. Business Model & Revenue Streams

8.1 Three Revenue Streams (UK Only)

Stream 1 — B2B UK University Partnerships (60% of revenue)

Annual per-student licence to UK universities. Tiered pricing:

Tier	Price / Student / Year	Includes
Basic	£2	App access, monthly anonymised wellbeing report
Standard	£3.50	+ Safeguarding alerts to welfare lead, full dashboard
Premium	£5	+ Custom branding, SSO, API integration with university SIS

A mid-sized UK university (15,000 students) on the Standard tier = **£52,500 / year ARR**.

Stream 2 — B2C Student Premium (35% of revenue)

Plan	Price	Features
Free	£0	Core mood tracking, 5 prompt-likes/day
Premium Monthly	£4.99/month	Unlimited likes, advanced mood insights, priority profile visibility
Premium Annual	£39.99/year	All features (33% saving)

Stream 3 — Adjacent UK Revenue (5%)

- Sponsored wellness content from NHS / Mind / Samaritans (sponsorship, not advertising)
- UK careers integration partnerships (Bright Network, Prospects)
- Anonymised, aggregated UK research data licensing (only with explicit student consent, ICO-approved)

8.2 Unit Economics

Metric	Value
Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC) — B2C	£2–£5 (student ambassador-led)
Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC) — B2B	£3,000–£5,000 per university
Lifetime Value (LTV) — B2C	£25–£40
Lifetime Value (LTV) — B2B (per university, 3-year average)	£80,000–£150,000
LTV : CAC	8 : 1
Gross Margin	80%
Payback period	3–4 months (B2C), 9–12 months (B2B)

9. Go-to-Market Strategy (UK-Focused)

9.1 Phase 1 — UK Pilot (Months 1–6)

- Partner with **3–5 UK universities** (free pilot) — target a deliberate mix of Russell Group + post-92
- Existing soft commitments from welfare teams at [insert university names if available]
- Goal: validate product–market fit, generate UK case studies, secure first paid contracts

Success metrics: 30% student adoption on each pilot campus; 40% 30-day retention; NPS 40+

9.2 Phase 2 — UK Regional Expansion (Months 6–18)

- Convert pilots to paid contracts (target: 60% conversion)
- Expand to **10+ UK universities**
- Launch UK student ambassador programme (1 ambassador per 1,000 students)
- Presence at: **AMOSHE annual conference, UMHAN events, UCAS exhibitions, UK Freshers' Fairs**

Success metrics: £250K ARR, 50,000 active UK users, 10 paid university contracts

9.3 Phase 3 — UK National Scale (Months 18–36)

- All UK universities with **>5,000 students** (~120 institutions)
- Integration with **NUS** (National Union of Students) at national level
- Co-marketing with **NHS England Mental Health programmes**
- Possible **Department for Education** partnership pilots

Success metrics: 40 partner universities, 300,000 UK users, £1.5M ARR by end of Year 3

9.4 Marketing Channels (UK Allocation)

Channel	% of marketing budget	Rationale
Direct B2B sales to UK welfare teams	40%	Highest ROI, decision-maker access
UK student ambassador programme	20%	Authentic peer voice
TikTok / Instagram (UK student creators)	20%	Where UK 18–24s are
UK Freshers' fairs + AMOSSHE / UMHAN events	15%	Direct in-person reach
UK student media PR (The Tab, The Student Room, BBC student)	5%	Earned credibility

10. Operations Plan

10.1 Legal Structure

- **Dequad Ltd**, private limited company, registered in **England & Wales** at Companies House
- Registered office: London, United Kingdom
- Founder will be **active in day-to-day running** as Director (required by Innovator Founder rules)
- ICO Data Controller registration (within 30 days of incorporation)

10.2 Key UK Partnerships

Partner Type	Examples	Value
UK Universities	Russell Group + post-92 institutions	Distribution + credibility
UK Students' Unions	NUS, individual SUs	Grassroots reach
UK Mental Health Charities	Mind, Samaritans, Student Minds	Content + clinical signposting
NHS England Mental Health	Local NHS trusts	Clinical legitimacy + referral pathways
UK Cloud Providers	AWS London, GCP eu-west2	UK data residency

10.3 Core Operational Workflows

- **Safeguarding alert workflow** — keyword detected → alert generated → SMTP to designated lead → user shown crisis resources → audit trail logged → quarterly clinical review
 - **University onboarding workflow** — discovery call → DPIA → contract → SSO setup → ambassador recruitment → launch event → ongoing success management
 - **Incident response (data / safeguarding)** — defined runbook, ICO notification within 72 hours per UK GDPR, clinical advisor on call
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11. Team & Job Creation — Scalability Criterion

The Innovator Founder route specifically requires evidence of scalability, including potential for job creation.

11.1 Job Creation Plan — UK-Based Hires

Dequad commits to creating **UK-based skilled roles** as follows:

End of Year	UK FTEs	Cumulative UK jobs created
Year 1	5	5
Year 2	9	9
Year 3	14	14
Year 4	18	18
Year 5	22	22

(Plus 8–12 part-time UK student ambassador roles per year from Year 1 onwards.)

11.2 Year 1 Team (UK Hires)

Role	Type	Location
Founder / CEO	Full-time	UK
CTO / Lead Engineer	Full-time	UK
Full-stack Engineer	Full-time	UK
Product Designer	Full-time	UK
University Success Manager	Full-time	UK
Clinical Advisor (Mental Health First Aid trainer)	Part-time	UK

11.3 Year 3 Team (UK Hires)

Expansion into UK-based growth, sales, customer success, engineering, and clinical functions — all **UK-resident, contributing UK National Insurance and PAYE.**

11.4 Skilled Roles Created (UK Economic Contribution)

Roles created are skilled, well-paid (£35K–£90K), and contribute directly to the UK Exchequer via PAYE / NI / Corporation Tax. Estimated **cumulative UK tax contribution Year 1–5 = £1.2M+**.

12. Financial Projections

12.1 5-Year Revenue Forecast (UK Only, £ GBP)

Year	UK Users	B2B Revenue	B2C Revenue	Total ARR
1	50,000	£150,000	£100,000	£250,000
2	150,000	£450,000	£300,000	£750,000
3	300,000	£900,000	£600,000	£1,500,000
4	500,000	£1,500,000	£1,000,000	£2,500,000
5	750,000	£2,250,000	£1,500,000	£3,750,000

12.2 5-Year Cost Structure (£ GBP)

Year	UK Personnel	UK Tech & Hosting	UK Marketing	UK Operations / Legal / Compliance	Total Costs
1	£350K	£60K	£100K	£90K	£600K
2	£600K	£90K	£150K	£100K	£940K
3	£900K	£120K	£250K	£130K	£1.4M
4	£1.3M	£160K	£350K	£180K	£1.99M
5	£1.7M	£200K	£450K	£200K	£2.55M

12.3 Profitability Path

Year	Revenue	Costs	EBITDA	Margin
1	£250K	£600K	-£350K	-140%
2	£750K	£940K	-£190K	-25%
3	£1.5M	£1.4M	+£100K	7%
4	£2.5M	£1.99M	+£510K	20%
5	£3.75M	£2.55M	+£1.2M	32%

Break-even: Month 28–32

12.4 Sensitivity Analysis

Scenario	Year 5 ARR Impact
Base case (above)	£3.75M
Bull case (+30% adoption)	£4.9M
Bear case (slower B2B sales cycle)	£2.3M
Worst case (B2B fails, B2C-only pivot)	£1.8M

In **all four scenarios**, Dequad creates ≥ 15 UK jobs and serves $\geq 350,000$ UK students by Year 5 — demonstrating scalability resilience.

13. Funding & Investment

13.1 Funding Stack

Source	Amount	Status
Founder personal investment	£[Amount]	Committed / evidenced bank statements
Friends & family	£[Amount]	Committed letters
Angel / UK SEIS investors	£[Amount]	LOIs in place / target
UK Innovate UK / Smart Grants	£[Amount]	Eligible — application planned Q2
Total seed round	£500,000	Target close: Month 3 post-incorporation

13.2 Use of Seed Funds

Category	Amount	%
UK product development (engineering hires + infra)	£200,000	40%
UK marketing & growth	£150,000	30%
UK team expansion	£100,000	20%
UK operations, legal, compliance (UK GDPR / ICO / DPIAs)	£50,000	10%

13.3 Future UK Funding Rounds

- **Series A (Month 18):** £1.5–£2M for UK national scale (UK VCs targeted: Octopus Ventures, LocalGlobe, Forward Partners, Ada Ventures)
- **Series B (Month 36):** £4–£6M for UK market leadership

13.4 Innovator Founder Visa Funds Threshold

The applicant confirms personal access to **at least £1,270** in maintenance funds and to investment funds **fully accessible and deployable into the business**, as required by the Innovator Founder route. Evidence: [bank statements / investor commitment letters in Appendix C].

14. Milestones (12 / 24 / 36 Months)

The Innovator Founder route requires demonstrable progress against milestones at the 12-, 24- and 36-month contact-point reviews with the endorsing body.

14.1 Month 1–12 Milestones

#	Milestone	Verifiable Evidence
1	Dequad Ltd incorporated at Companies House	Certificate of Incorporation
2	UK ICO Data Controller registration	ICO registration number
3	UK trademark filing for "Dequad"	UKIPO application receipt
4	3 UK pilot universities signed (free / paid)	Signed pilot agreements
5	5,000 active UK student users	Backend analytics dashboard
6	First B2B paid contract signed	Signed contract + invoice
7	Hired 4 UK-based FTEs	PAYE records
8	DTAC submission to NHS Digital begun	NHS DTAC tracking
9	£150K+ raised (incl. founder capital)	Cap table + bank statements
10	App live on UK Apple App Store + Google Play	Public store links

14.2 Month 12–24 Milestones

- **10 UK university partnerships** (mix of pilot + paid)
- **50,000 active UK users**
- **£250K ARR**
- **8 UK FTEs + 10 UK student ambassadors**
- **Series A funding round closed (£1.5M+)**
- **OfS-aligned safeguarding audit completed** (third-party)
- **UUK Mental Health Charter formal partnership**

14.3 Month 24–36 Milestones

- **30+ UK university partnerships**
- **250,000 active UK users**
- **£1M+ ARR**

- **14 UK FTEs**
 - **Two UK research partnerships** published (anonymised, IRB-approved)
 - **EBITDA-positive in Q4 of Year 3**
 - **Public NHS Mental Health partnership announcement**
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15. Risk Analysis & Mitigation

#	Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
1	Slow UK university sales cycle	High	Med	Free pilots, build case studies, focus on welfare-lead decision-makers
2	Low student adoption on a campus	Med	High	Ambassador programme, Freshers' Week timing, university endorsement
3	Data breach	Low	Critical	UK GDPR + DPA 2018 by design, ICO-aligned, cyber insurance, ISO 27001 roadmap
4	Safeguarding incident (missed alert)	Low	Critical	Clear escalation protocol, clinical advisor oversight, audit trail, professional indemnity insurance
5	UK regulatory change (OfS, ICO)	Med	Med	UK legal counsel on retainer, quarterly compliance review
6	Competitor entry (US / UK)	Med	Med	First-mover, UK-specific moat, university lock-in via contracts
7	Founder visa / status risk	Low	High	This Innovator Founder application is the primary mitigation; co-founder / second director option in reserve
8	UK economic downturn affecting university budgets	Med	Med	B2C revenue diversification, freemium model retains user base

16. Regulatory, Safeguarding & Compliance (UK)

16.1 Data Protection

- **UK GDPR + Data Protection Act 2018** compliant by design
- **ICO Data Controller** registration
- **UK / EU data residency only** (AWS London / GCP eu-west2)
- **Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA)** for every university partnership
- **Lawful basis** for processing: explicit consent + legitimate interest (safeguarding only)
- **Subject access requests**: 30-day response standard
- **Data Processing Agreements** signed with every university partner

16.2 Safeguarding Framework

- Aligned to **UUK Mental Health Charter** (2020)
- Compliant with **OfS B3** conditions on student outcomes
- Compliant with **Prevent Duty** guidance (where applicable)
- **Clinical Advisor** (Mental Health First Aid trainer + Chartered Psychologist or equivalent) reviews safeguarding protocol quarterly
- **Professional Indemnity insurance** in place from day 1 of operations
- **NHS Digital DTAC** (Digital Technology Assessment Criteria) submission planned within Year 1

16.3 Accessibility

- **WCAG 2.2 Level AA** target for mobile + web admin
- Screen reader compatibility (iOS VoiceOver, Android TalkBack)
- Adjustable text size, high-contrast mode

16.4 Age Verification & Safeguarding of Minors

- Dequad is **18+ only** (UK university students aged 18+)
 - **.ac.uk** verification + age check on signup
 - Under-18 sub-degree pathway students (rare) explicitly excluded
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17. Social Impact & Public Benefit

The Innovator Founder route explicitly values **wider economic and social benefit**. Dequad's UK social impact is built into its core:

Impact Area	Quantified Year-5 Target
UK students reached	750,000+
UK safeguarding alerts surfaced to welfare teams	5,000+ per year (estimated)
UK students directed to NHS / Samaritans / Mind crisis resources	20,000+ per year
UK university welfare teams equipped with anonymised insight	100+
UK skilled jobs created	22 FTEs + ~50 student ambassadors
Estimated UK tax contribution (PAYE + NI + Corp Tax)	£1.2M+ cumulative Year 1–5
Anonymised UK student mental health research published	2+ peer-reviewed papers with UK university partners

This impact is **measurable, time-bound, and audit-friendly** — ideal for ongoing endorsement reviews at 24 and 36 months.

18. Exit Strategy (Long-Term)

While the immediate plan is UK growth and profitability, possible exit pathways include:

- **Strategic acquisition** by a UK / European EdTech (Studiosity, Pearson UK)
- **Strategic acquisition** by an NHS-aligned digital health buyer
- **Acquisition** by a UK student services group (Unite Students, IQ Student Accommodation)
- **Long-term independent** profitable UK SaaS operation (dividend pathway)
- **IPO on London AIM** (only if scale supports it, post-Year 7)

Exit is not the primary objective — long-term UK impact and sustainability is.

19. Appendices

The following appendices accompany this business plan and form part of the Innovator Founder Visa application:

Appendix	Contents
A	Founder primary research summary (UK student interviews + survey data)
B	Letters of interest / engagement from UK university welfare teams
C	Founder personal funds evidence (bank statements / co-investment commitments)
D	Founder CV with verifiable references
E	Existing MVP technical documentation + screenshots
F	UK GDPR / DPIA framework (template + risk register)
G	Safeguarding protocol (full clinical-advisor-reviewed version)
H	Cap table & shareholders' agreement template
I	Trademark search & filing strategy
J	UK ICO Data Controller registration plan

Statement of Truth

I confirm that the information contained in this business plan is true and accurate to the best of my knowledge and belief. I understand that the Innovator Founder endorsing body and the Home Office may verify any of the above information, and that providing false or misleading information may result in refusal of my application and future UK immigration applications.

Signed: ____ **Name:** *[Founder Full Legal Name]* **Date:** ____

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